2026 Chocó Earthquake (Colombia)

M7.4, San José del Palmar, Chocó Department - 10 August 2026

Mww 7.4 · depth 107 km · MMI VII (Very strong) — USGS ShakeMap; the SGC macroseismic intensity map agrees · GLIDE EQ-2026-000146-COL

(1) World / Colombia

(2) NW South America

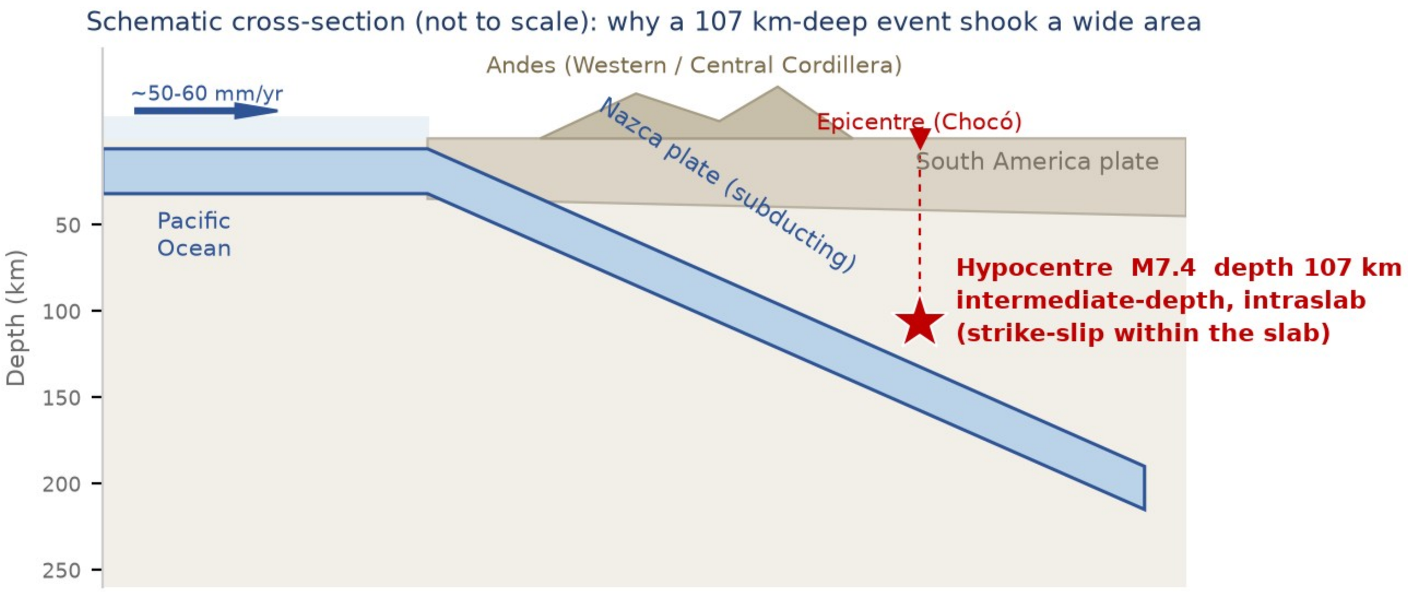
(3) Epicentre & affected cities

Locator maps © Google (Google Maps). Distances shown on later pages are computed from the published USGS coordinates.

Overview At 07:34 local time (12:34 UTC) on 10 August 2026, an Mww 7.4 earthquake struck western Colombia with its epicentre 5 km east of San José del Palmar in Chocó Department, at a depth of about 107 km (USGS). The event was an intermediate-depth, strike-slip rupture inside the subducting Nazca slab; because of its depth, strong shaking (MMI VI-VII) was spread over a wide area of the Andean Coffee Region rather than concentrated near the epicentre, and about 10.5 million people were exposed to it. The SGC describes it as the largest-magnitude earthquake recorded in Colombia in the past decade. As of 17:00 COT on 10 August the Government reported 111 deaths and 87 injured, more than 1,600 buildings damaged (1,575 homes damaged, 37 destroyed, 61 buildings collapsed), together with damage to 18 health facilities, 52 educational facilities, 18 major roads and six regional airports. The passenger terminal of Matecaña International Airport in Pereira partially collapsed, a tower of the neo-Gothic cathedral in Manizales fell onto the nave, and about 30% of the University Hospital in Cali collapsed. The President declared a national disaster, set up a Unified Command Post in Chocó and deployed four USAR teams and the armed forces. There was no tsunami. All figures are preliminary and are expected to change as assessment proceeds.

Sources: USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqqmro (this earthquake) · UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · Google Maps

Seismotectonic Setting: an intraslab earthquake



Schematic cross-section (ADRC)

[Official] Depth about 107 km (USGS): an intraslab event, not a plate-interface megathrust.

[Official] Strike-slip mechanism within the descending Nazca slab (USGS tectonic summary).

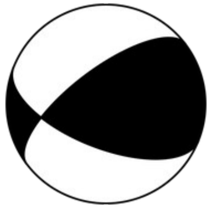
[Official] Maximum shaking MMI VII (Very strong); about 10.5 million people exposed to MMI VI-VII.

[Official] USGS PAGER Orange alert: estimated fatalities of the order of 300 and estimated economic loss of the order of USD 880 million (model estimates, not observations).

[Official] The SGC assesses this as the largest-magnitude earthquake recorded in Colombia in the past decade.

[Media] Shaking was reported as unusually long in duration in cities far from the epicentre - a characteristic of deep events recorded on soft valley sediments.

Colombia lies at the junction of the Nazca, Caribbean and South America plates. Off the Pacific coast the Nazca plate subducts eastward beneath South America at roughly 50-60 mm/yr, and the descending slab reaches intermediate depths (70-300 km) beneath the Western and Central Cordilleras. This event ruptured inside that slab at about 107 km depth, which is why the shaking was felt over hundreds of kilometres - as far as Bogotá, Quito and Panamá City - while surface faulting and tsunami generation were absent. Intermediate-depth events radiate high-frequency energy efficiently and attenuate slowly, so damage tends to be distributed across many cities rather than concentrated in a narrow epicentral zone.



Focal mechanism (beachball)
Both agencies report a strike-slip mechanism.

Sources: USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqqmro (this earthquake) · GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026

Overview of the Earthquake & Response Measures

10 Aug 2026, 07:34 COT (12:34 UTC / 21:34 JST) | Mww 7.4 | depth 107 km | MMI VII (Very strong) — USGS ShakeMap; the SGC macroseismic intensity map agrees

Figures as of 10 Aug 2026, 17:00 COT (11 Aug 07:00 JST), approx. 9.5 hours after the earthquake. All figures are preliminary.

[Official] The Government declared a national disaster (desastre nacional), enabling extraordinary mobilisation and coordination of the response.

[Official] President Abelardo de la Espriella - in office for three days - ordered a Unified Command Post (PMU) in Chocó to coordinate the emergency, and travelled to Pereira, one of the worst-hit cities.

[Official] The National Unit for Disaster Risk Management (UNGRD) activated the national system, verified damage with departmental and municipal authorities, and channelled offers of assistance together with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

[Official] Four USAR (urban search and rescue) groups were deployed from Bogotá, Envigado, Yopal and Medellín to reinforce search and rescue.

[Official] Soldiers were deployed to the affected departments for search, rescue and route clearance.

[Official] Civil aviation suspended flights at Pereira, Manizales, Quibdó, Armenia, Cartago and Buenaventura while runways and terminals were inspected.

[Media] Damaged buildings, power outages and communications disruption are slowing assessment in parts of Chocó closest to the epicentre.

[Official] GLIDE number assigned for this event: EQ-2026-000146-COL.

Sources: UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · Colombia One - Government declares national disaster · France 24 - Colombia declares national emergency as quake toll hits 111

Chronology of the Response (10 August) (1/2)

Times are Colombia time (COT, UTC-5). The earthquake occurred at 07:34 COT = 21:34 JST on 10 August.

Time	Action	Source
07:34	Mww 7.4 earthquake, epicentre 5 km E of San José del Palmar (Chocó), depth approx. 107 km. Felt in Bogotá, Cali, Medellín, and in Ecuador, Panama and Venezuela.	**USGS / SGC**
07:40s	The SGC issues a first bulletin (initially M6.6, 79 km depth), later revised to M7.4 at 96 km, located with 69 stations (event SGC2026pqqmro); damage-assessment protocols activated.	**SGC**
Morning	UNGRD reports first damage indications in 9 municipalities of Chocó, 8 of Caldas, 2 of Valle del Cauca and 2 of Risaralda, plus localities in Quindío.	**UNGRD**
Morning	Cali reports collapsed structures at 12 critical points with people trapped; part of the University Hospital collapses.	**Mayor of Cali**
Morning	Manizales reports 17 buildings collapsed and 19 partially collapsed; a tower of the neo-Gothic cathedral falls onto the nave. Residents asked to stay outdoors because of aftershocks.	**Mayor of Manizales**
Morning	Passenger terminal of Matecaña International Airport (Pereira) partially collapses; flights suspended at six regional airports.	**Aerocivil / media**
Daytime	National disaster declared; Unified Command Post established in Chocó; armed forces deployed.	**Government**

Sources: USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead · Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage

Chronology of the Response (10 August) (2/2)

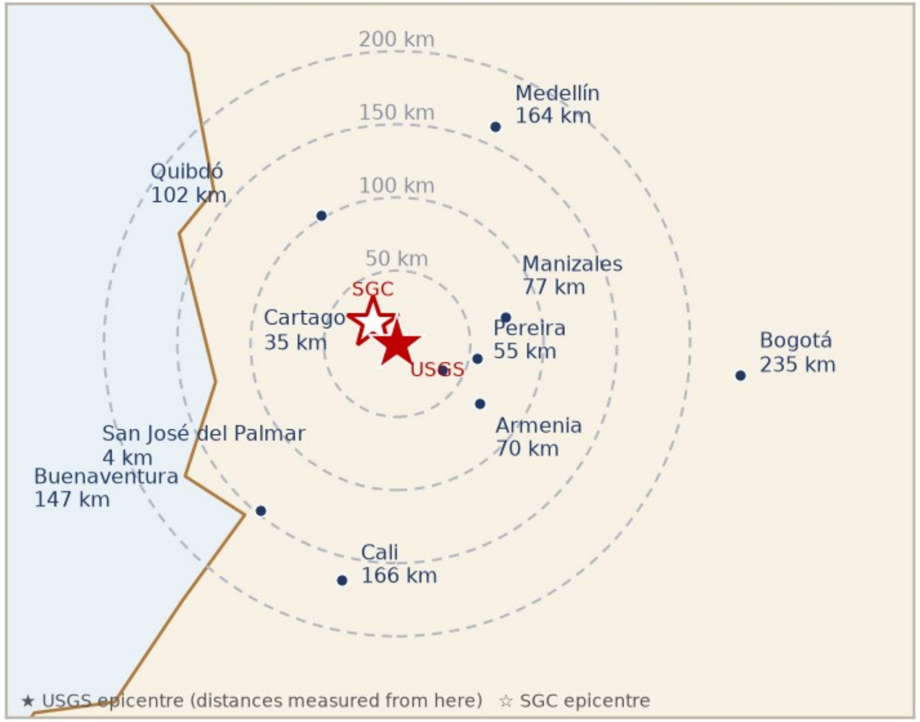
Times are Colombia time (COT, UTC-5). The earthquake occurred at 07:34 COT = 21:34 JST on 10 August.

Time	Action	Source
Daytime	Four USAR teams deployed from Bogotá, Envigado, Yopal and Medellín.	**UNGRD**
Daytime	More than 20 aftershocks recorded; the largest widely felt aftershock is M4.8.	**SGC**
Daytime	President travels to Pereira to lead the response on the ground.	**Presidency**
12:13	Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping activated as EMSR916 (17:13 UTC), requested by EC Services / DG ECHO, for earthquake damage assessment mapping.	**Copernicus EMS**
Afternoon	First national damage report: 111 deaths, 87 injured; 1,575 homes damaged, 37 destroyed, 61 buildings collapsed; 18 health facilities, 52 educational facilities, 17 community facilities, 18 major roads and 6 regional airports damaged.	**Presidency / UNGRD**
Afternoon	Ecuador mobilises a 47-person USAR team with canine units; Mexico and other governments offer assistance, to be channelled through the Foreign Ministry and UNGRD.	**International media**

Sources: USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead · Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage

Affected Departments & Cities

Epicentre and main affected cities (epicentral distance)



Epicentral distances (ADRC)

Why damage is dispersed
A 107 km-deep source puts every city in the region at a broadly similar hypocentral distance (108-200 km), so no single city sits in a narrow zone of extreme shaking.

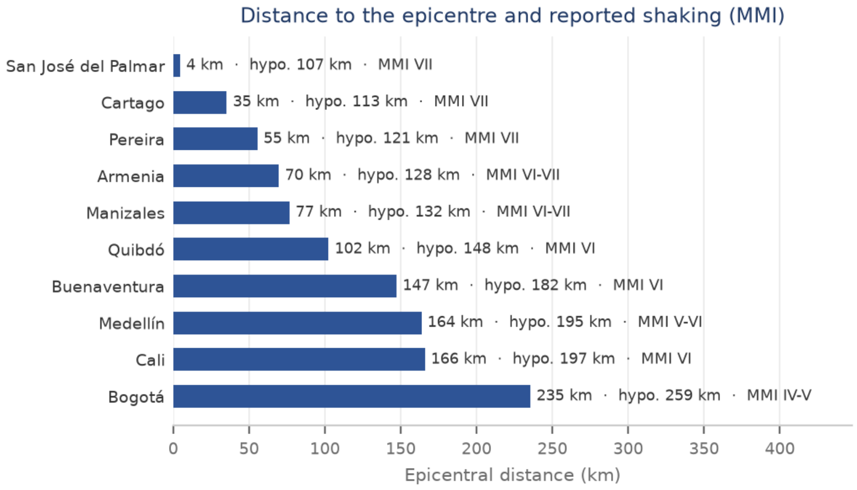
Department	Main cities	Dist.	MMI	Situation
Chocó	San José del Palmar / Quibdó	4 / 102 km	**VII / VI**	Epicentral department; 9 municipalities with reported damage; access, power and communications constrained.
Risaralda	Pereira, Dosquebradas	55 km	**VII**	Highest reported death toll (at least 40; the governor cites at least 42). Airport terminal partially collapsed.
Valle del Cauca	Cali, Cartago, Buenaventura	166 / 35 / 147 km	**VI-VII**	27 deaths reported; 25-30 collapsed structures at 12 critical points in Cali; University Hospital heavily damaged.
Caldas	Manizales	77 km	**VI-VII**	8 municipalities affected; 17 buildings collapsed and 19 partially collapsed in Manizales; cathedral tower fell onto the nave.
Quindío	Armenia and other localities	70 km	**VI-VII**	Several localities reported affected; the same Coffee Region devastated by the 1999 Armenia earthquake.
Antioquia	Medellín and surroundings	164 km	**V-VI**	One death reported (a 73-year-old); structural damage under inspection.
Cundinamarca / Bogotá	Bogotá, Nilo	235 km	**IV-V**	Widely felt; buildings evacuated; structural damage to a school in Nilo reported.

Sources: UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage · CBS News - Strong earthquake strikes western Colombia

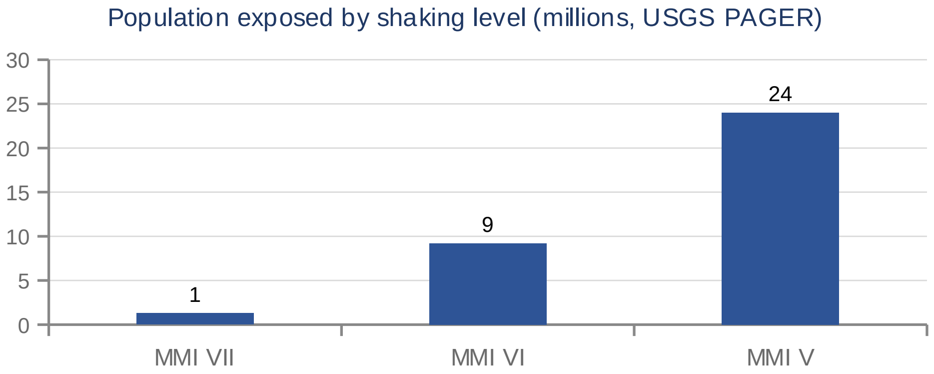
Event Parameters & Observed Shaking

Item	Value
Origin time (local)	10 Aug 2026, 07:34 COT (UTC-5)
Origin time (UTC / JST)	10 Aug 2026, 12:34 UTC / 10 Aug 2026, 21:34 JST
Epicentre	USGS: 5 km E of San José del Palmar, Chocó Department (approx. 280 km W of Bogotá) — SGC: 20 km from San José del Palmar
Coordinates	USGS 4.9031 N, 76.1885 W · SGC 5.04 N, 76.34 W
Magnitude	Mww 7.4 (USGS) · 7.4 (SGC)
Depth	107 km (USGS) / 96 km (SGC)
Mechanism	Strike-slip faulting at intermediate depth, within the subducting Nazca slab (not on the shallow plate interface)
Max. shaking	MMI VII (Very strong) — USGS ShakeMap; the SGC macroseismic intensity map agrees
Felt area	Felt across western and central Colombia including Bogotá, Cali and Medellín, and in Ecuador, Panama and Venezuela
Tsunami	No tsunami. The event was inland and at intermediate depth; no tsunami warning was issued for the Pacific coast.
Alert level	USGS PAGER: Orange (significant casualties and damage likely). GDACS: Orange.
GLIDE	EQ-2026-000146-COL

USGS and SGC agree on size; the SGC's first bulletin gave M6.6 at 79 km before revision. The two locations differ by about 20 km and their depths by about 11 km — normal for an intermediate-depth event recorded by different networks. Epicentral distances in this report are measured from the USGS location. SGC event SGC2026pqqmro was located with 69 stations; the SGC states its bulletins are subject to change as review continues.



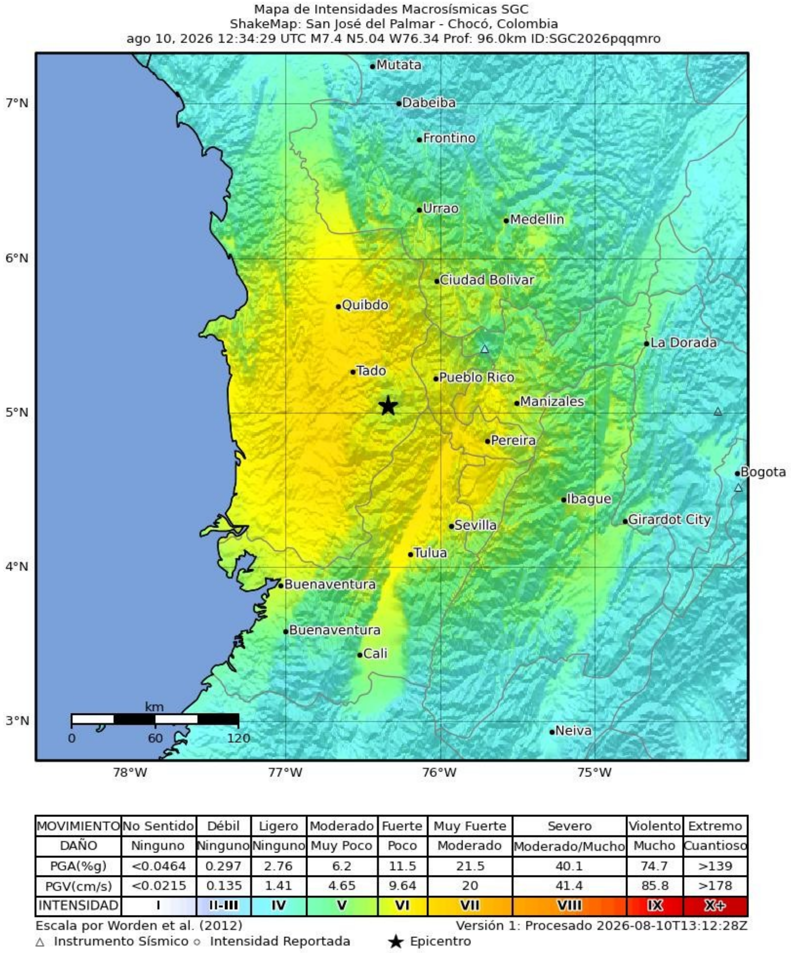
Distance vs. reported MMI (ADRC)



USGS PAGER exposure estimates. About 10.5 million people experienced Strong to Very Strong shaking (MMI VI-VII) and an estimated 34 million people across four countries felt the earthquake. These are model estimates.

Sources: USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqqmro (this earthquake) · GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026

Macroseismic Intensity (SGC)



Official SGC intensity map (© SGC) — https://www.sgc.gov.co/detallesismo/SGC2026pqqmro/mmi

ShakeMap: San José del Palmar - Chocó, Colombia · 10 Aug 2026 12:34:29 UTC · M7.4 · N5.04 W76.34 · depth 96.0 km · ID SGC2026pqqmro · Version 1, processed 2026-08-10T13:12:28Z · scale after Worden et al. (2012)

The SGC map shows the strongest band (MMI VII, 'Muy Fuerte') over the epicentral area of Chocó and along the inter-Andean corridor through Risaralda, Caldas, Quindío and northern Valle del Cauca — the belt in which the collapses in Pereira, Manizales, Armenia and Cartago occurred. Intensity falls away eastward: Medellín and Cali sit in the moderate-to-strong bands and Bogotá, 235 km from the epicentre, in a low one. The elongated pattern along the valleys, rather than a compact circle around the epicentre, is the signature of a 96-107 km-deep source combined with soft valley sediments.

MMI	Perceived shaking	Potential damage	PGA (%g)	PGV (cm/s)
I	Not felt	None	<0.0464	<0.0215
II-III	Weak	None	0.297	0.135
IV	Light	None	2.76	1.41
V	Moderate	Very light	6.2	4.65
VI	Strong	Light	11.5	9.64
VII	Very strong	Moderate	21.5	20
VIII	Severe	Moderate/heavy	40.1	41.4
IX	Violent	Heavy	74.7	85.8
X+	Extreme	Very heavy	>139	>178

Modified Mercalli scale (Worden et al., 2012), as printed on the SGC map

Sources: SGC — macroseismic intensity map (ShakeMap) for this earthquake · SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqqmro (this earthquake) · USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page)

Seismicity: Aftershocks

Time	Magnitude	Note	Tier
10 Aug, after 07:34	**M4.8**	Largest aftershock on the SGC event bulletin; widely felt	**Official**
10 Aug, after 07:34	**M2.8**	The second aftershock listed on the SGC event bulletin	**Official**
10 Aug (to 17:00)	**20+ reported**	Media reported more than 20 aftershocks during the day; the SGC event bulletin listed two at the time of writing	**Media**

The SGC event bulletin (SGC2026pqqmro) listed two aftershocks, M2.8 and M4.8, the latter widely felt; media reported more than 20 during the day. Aftershock sequences of intermediate-depth intraslab events are typically less productive than those of shallow crustal earthquakes, but strong aftershocks remain possible and already-damaged buildings are vulnerable to them.

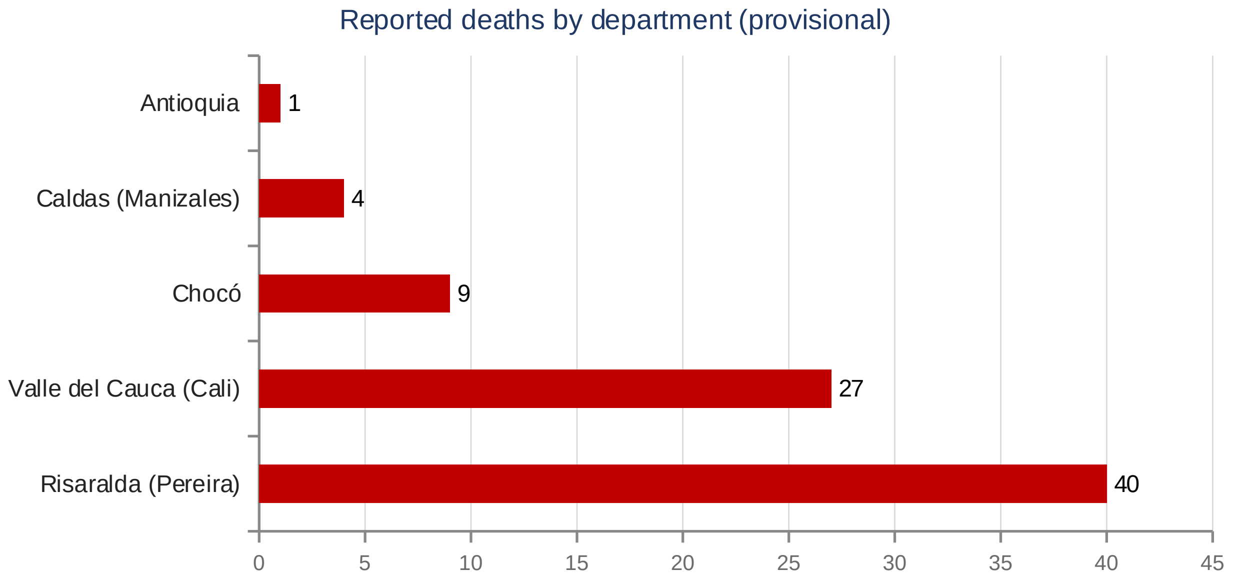
Operational implication

Buildings that survived the mainshock in a damaged state have lost capacity. Even moderate aftershocks can bring them down, so rapid habitability assessment before re-occupancy - and keeping people out of visibly damaged structures - matters as much as the aftershock statistics themselves.

Sources: Servicio Geológico Colombiano (SGC) · USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page)

Human Damage

Deaths	Injured	Buildings damaged
111	87	1,600+



Department	Deaths	Note
Risaralda (Pereira)	40	Governor cites at least 42
Valle del Cauca (Cali)	27	
Chocó	9	Epicentral department
Caldas (Manizales)	4	Reported as 2, later 4
Antioquia	1	73-year-old

Reading the numbers
Departmental figures come from local authorities and are reported at different times; they do not yet add up to the national total of 111 and will be reconciled as verification proceeds.

Sources: France 24 - Colombia declares national emergency as quake toll hits 111 · CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead · CBS News - Strong earthquake strikes western Colombia · NBC News - Deaths, injuries and collapsed buildings

Damage: Buildings, Services & Lifelines (1/2)

All figures preliminary. Official (government) figures are primary; media-sourced items are labelled.

Item	Reported	Source	Tier
Deaths	111	Presidency / UNGRD, 10 Aug afternoon	Official
Injured	87	Presidency / UNGRD, 10 Aug afternoon	Official
Missing / trapped	Not yet quantified; people were reported trapped under rubble in Cali, Pereira and Manizales	Local authorities (media)	Media
Buildings damaged (total)	More than 1,600	Presidency, 10 Aug	Official
Homes damaged	1,575	UNGRD, 10 Aug	Official
Homes destroyed	37	UNGRD, 10 Aug	Official
Buildings collapsed	61 nationally; Cali 25-30 at 12 critical points, Manizales 17 collapsed + 19 partial	UNGRD; mayors of Cali and Manizales	Official
Health facilities	18 damaged; 7 health institutions closed; about 30% of the University Hospital in Cali collapsed, including three floors (paediatrics, internal medicine, part of the neonatal unit)	UNGRD; Valle del Cauca government	Official

Sources: UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage · CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead

Damage: Buildings, Services & Lifelines (2/2)

All figures preliminary. Official (government) figures are primary; media-sourced items are labelled.

Item	Reported	Source	Tier
Educational facilities	52 damaged; schools evacuated across the affected departments	UNGRD, 10 Aug	**Official**
Community facilities	17 damaged	UNGRD, 10 Aug	**Official**
Roads	18 major roads and highways damaged	UNGRD, 10 Aug	**Official**
Airports	6 regional airports damaged; Matecaña International (Pereira) passenger terminal partially collapsed; flights suspended at Pereira, Manizales, Quibdó, Armenia, Cartago and Buenaventura	UNGRD; civil aviation authority	**Official**
Cultural heritage	A tower of the neo-Gothic Cathedral of Manizales collapsed onto the nave	Mayor of Manizales	**Media**
Lifelines	Power outages and communications disruption reported in areas near the epicentre; systematic figures not yet published	Media / humanitarian agencies	**Media**
Displacement	Thousands reported to have left their homes; shelter figures not yet published	Media / humanitarian agencies	**Media**

Sources: UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage · CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead

National Response

[Official] National disaster declaration activating the National Disaster Risk Management System (SNGRD) under Law 1523 of 2012.

[Official] Unified Command Post (PMU) established in Chocó; UNGRD coordinating with departmental and municipal risk-management councils.

[Official] Four USAR teams (Bogotá, Envigado, Yopal, Medellín) deployed for search and rescue in collapsed structures.

[Official] Armed forces deployed for search, rescue, route clearance and security in the affected departments.

[Official] Rapid structural inspection of hospitals, schools and airports; seven health institutions closed and six airports suspended pending assessment.

[Media] Patients transferred from the damaged University Hospital in Cali to other facilities; the city reported casualties concentrated at 12 critical collapse sites.

Legal basis
The national disaster declaration activates the SNGRD established by Law 1523 of 2012, allowing UNGRD to direct resources and the national disaster fund (FNGRD) to be used without the ordinary procurement timelines.

Sources: UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · Colombia One - Government declares national disaster · PreventionWeb - Colombia PNGRD 2015-2030

International Support

[Official] Ecuador mobilised a specialised USAR team of 47 personnel with canine units and self-sufficient equipment.

[Media] Mexico's President pledged 'all the support required'; several Latin American governments offered rescuers, canine teams and humanitarian aid, to be channelled through Colombia's Foreign Ministry and UNGRD.

[Official] Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping activated as EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' at 17:13 UTC on 10 August (12:13 COT), requested by EC Services / DG ECHO, to provide earthquake damage assessment emergency mapping. Status ongoing, with 3 areas of interest and 3 products at the time of writing. The activation reason names Quibdó, Pereira, Manizales and Cali as cities with significant damage and collapsed buildings.

[TBC] The International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' is also reported to have been activated for this earthquake; the activation number had not been confirmed at the time of writing.

[Media] International NGOs mobilising: Direct Relief and Americares (medical supplies), Save the Children (child protection and education), International Rescue Committee (assessment near the epicentre in Chocó), Convoy of Hope (relief goods).

[TBC] No announcement by the Government of Japan (message of condolence, emergency grant aid or JDR dispatch) had been identified at the time of writing.

Channelling
Offers of assistance are to be channelled through Colombia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs together with UNGRD.

Sources: International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' - activations · Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' (activation) · ReliefWeb - Colombia

Satellite & Analytical Support

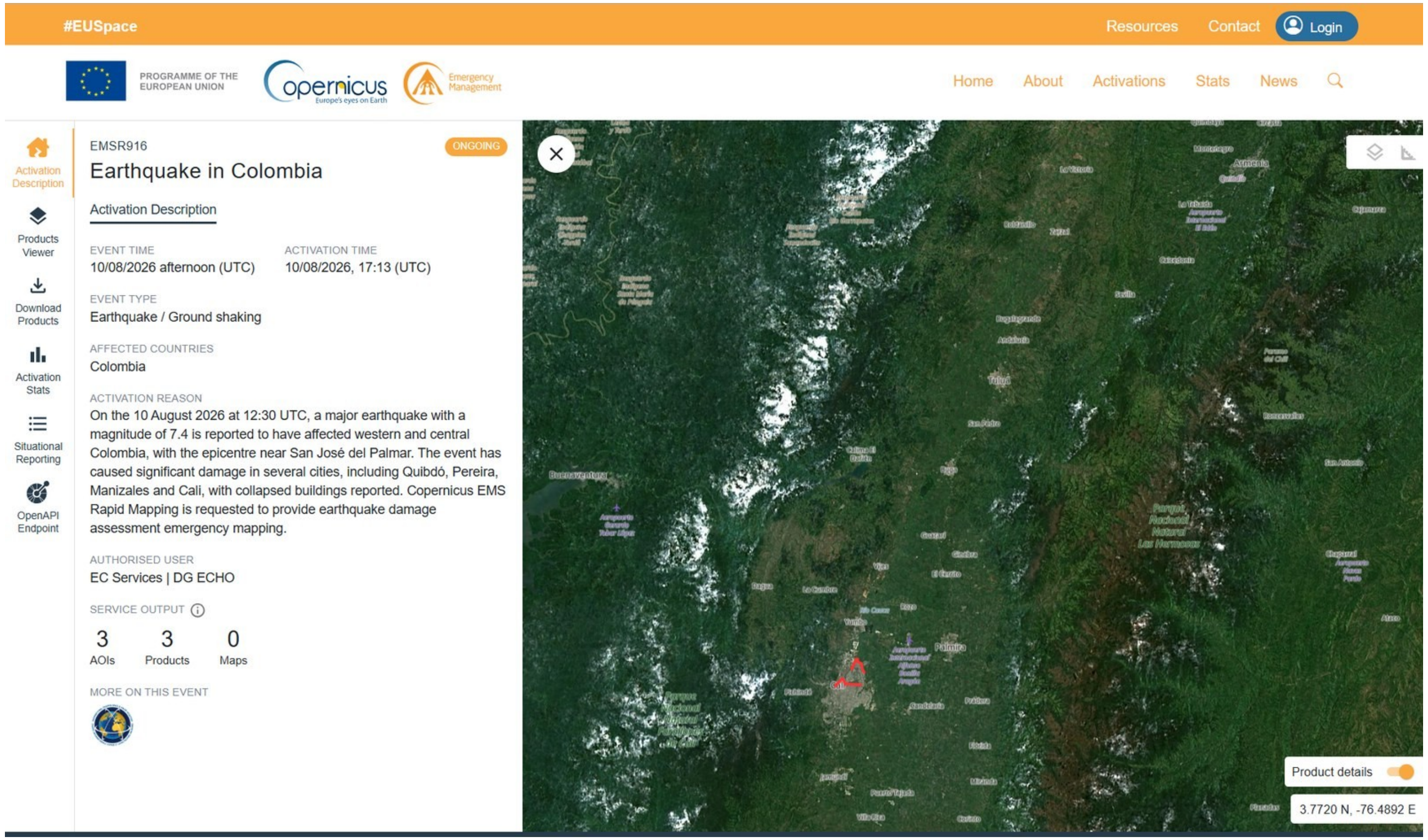
Organisation	Contribution	Status	Tier
International Charter	Activation for the Colombia earthquake reported; wide-area optical/SAR imagery for damage assessment	Reported / number pending	TBC
Copernicus EMS	EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' — Rapid Mapping for damage assessment; requested by EC Services / DG ECHO; 3 AOIs, 3 products	Ongoing (EMSR916)	Official
USGS	ShakeMap, PAGER (Orange), finite-fault and aftershock catalogue	Published	Official
GDACS	Overall Orange alert; population exposure and impact estimates	Published	Official
SGC	National seismic network: hypocentre, magnitude revision, aftershock bulletins, accelerographic records	Published	Official
Sentinel Asia	Not applicable - the mechanism covers the Asia-Pacific region; Colombia is served by the International Charter and Copernicus EMS	n/a	Official

Note on Sentinel Asia

Sentinel Asia, for which ADRC serves as a joint project team member, covers the Asia-Pacific region. For a disaster in Colombia the equivalent international mechanisms are the International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' and the Copernicus Emergency Management Service; UNOSAT/UNITAR rapid mapping is also commonly used in Latin America.

Sources: International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' - activations · Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' (activation) · GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026

Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping: EMSR916



Activation page (© Copernicus EMS) — https://mapping.emergency.copernicus.eu/activations/EMSR916/

Item	Value
Activation	EMSR916 — Earthquake in Colombia
Event time	10/08/2026 afternoon (UTC)
Activation time	10/08/2026, 17:13 (UTC) = 12:13 COT
Event type	Earthquake / Ground shaking
Affected country	Colombia
Authorised user	EC Services | DG ECHO
Service output	3 AOIs · 3 products · 0 maps
Status	ONGOING

Activation reason (verbatim)

“On the 10 August 2026 at 12:30 UTC, a major earthquake with a magnitude of 7.4 is reported to have affected western and central Colombia, with the epicentre near San José del Palmar. The event has caused significant damage in several cities, including Quibdó, Pereira, Manizales and Cali, with collapsed buildings reported. Copernicus EMS Rapid Mapping is requested to provide earthquake damage assessment emergency mapping.”

What Rapid Mapping delivers

Rapid Mapping delivers reference and grading products over selected areas of interest, not nationwide coverage. Products are published on the activation page as they are produced and are free to use.

Sources: Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' (activation) · European Commission — EU support for Colombia, Copernicus activated

Colombia's Disaster Risk Management System

Colombia rebuilt its disaster risk management framework after the 1985 Armero volcanic disaster and again after the 1999 Armenia earthquake. Law 1523 of 2012 created the National Disaster Risk Management System (SNGRD), led by the National Unit for Disaster Risk Management (UNGRD), which reports to the Presidency.

- Law 1523 of 2012 - national policy on disaster risk management; defines the SNGRD and makes risk management a mandatory duty of every public authority and, in part, of private actors.
- UNGRD - national coordinating agency under the Presidency; runs the national response, the disaster fund (FNGRD) and the national information system.
- Departmental and municipal risk management councils (CDGRD / CMGRD) carry out first response; UNGRD reinforces when local capacity is exceeded.
- PNGRD 2015-2030 — the national disaster risk management plan, adopted by Decree 308 of 2016 and updated by Decree 1478 of 3 August 2022; aligned with the Sendai Framework and monitored annually by UNGRD.
- NSR-10 - the national seismic building code (in force since 2010, technical annexes updated since). Buildings predating modern code enforcement, and non-engineered masonry and earthen construction, remain the dominant source of risk.
- Seismic microzonation studies exist for major cities including Bogotá, Medellín, Cali, Pereira, Manizales and Armenia — a direct legacy of the 1999 earthquake. In Cali the microzonation is binding on structural design through Decree 411.0.20.0158 of 2014.
- The SGC operates the National Seismological Network and the national accelerograph network, and issues public bulletins within minutes.
- Cities run their own instruments alongside the national system: Cali's SATIC community-and-sensor early warning system (from 2018, formalised by Municipal Decree 0858 of 2022), Medellín's DAGRD and its municipal plan, and municipal risk-management funds created under Law 1523.

Sources: UN-SPIDER - UNGRD of Colombia · UNGRD — Plan Nacional de Gestión del Riesgo de Desastres (PNGRD) · Decreto 1478 de 2022 — update of the PNGRD · SATIC — Cali's intelligent and community early warning system

The 1999 Armenia (Quindío) Earthquake & Recovery

The 1999 Armenia (Quindío) Earthquake - the same Coffee Region

On 25 January 1999 an M6.1-6.2 earthquake at about 30 km depth struck the Quindío coffee-growing region. It killed about 1,185 people, injured over 5,000 and damaged or destroyed some 50,000 structures; roughly 60% of the buildings in the city of Armenia collapsed or were severely damaged, and more than 200,000 people were displaced. Although far smaller in magnitude than the 2026 event, it was much shallower and much closer to the cities, which is why its local destructiveness was far greater.

1999 impact	Figure
Deaths	approx. 1,185
Injured	over 5,000
Structures damaged or destroyed	approx. 50,000
Displaced	over 200,000
Coffee sector	approx. 8,000 farms and 1,200 processing facilities damaged

What followed / lessons

- Reconstruction was managed through a dedicated temporary body for the Coffee Region, an early example in Latin America of a purpose-built reconstruction agency.
- The disaster drove enforcement of the national seismic code and the seismic microzonation studies that now cover Pereira, Manizales and Armenia.
- Recovery of the coffee economy took roughly a decade - the economic tail of the disaster far outlasted the emergency phase.
- The 2026 earthquake shook the same cities, but as a deep, distant source rather than a shallow local one: a different loading of the same building stock.

Why this matters now

The cities hit hardest in 2026 - Pereira, Manizales, Armenia - are the same cities that rebuilt after 1999. How that rebuilt stock performed under long-period, long-duration shaking from a 107 km-deep source is the key question for post-event assessment.

Sources: GEM - Seismic regulations for Colombia (NSR-10) · PreventionWeb - Colombia PNGRD 2015-2030

Pre-event Risk Assessment: Santiago de Cali

Cali did not lack a risk assessment. Between 2020 and 2022 the city built a full urban earthquake risk model with the GEM Foundation under the USAID-supported TREQ project, one of three pilot cities alongside Quito and Santiago de los Caballeros. The modelled scenario is a shallow local one — magnitude 6.5 at 10 km depth on the Dagua-Cali fault — and its estimates dwarf what the city actually experienced on 10 August 2026.

Modelled scenario (GEM-TREQ, 2022)	Value
Modelled scenario	M6.5, 10 km depth, Dagua-Cali fault, urban area
Population exposed	approx. 2,300,000
Estimated deaths	approx. 1,200
Seriously injured	approx. 36,300
Displaced	approx. 181,000
Buildings collapsed	approx. 1,800 of 348,000 (0.5%)
Residual risk	assessed at about 40% after existing measures

Figures from the GEM-TREQ urban risk assessment for Santiago de Cali and from the city's local disaster risk management plan, as compiled by the Municipality of Santiago de Cali (Secretaría de Gestión del Riesgo de Emergencias y Desastres) for a JICA training course.

What the city had already prioritised

- Seismic vulnerability studies of indispensable buildings — hospitals, schools, fire stations — to the NSR-10 code (budgeted at about USD 1.7 million, short term).
- Structural retrofitting of indispensable buildings and of basic-service infrastructure, to keep essential services running after an earthquake.
- Seismic vulnerability assessment of the EMCALI water, sewerage and power networks and of the city gas network.
- Updating the local soil-response model and the seismic microzonation, in force since INGEOMINAS/DAGMA (2005) and adopted by Decree 411.0.20.0158 of 2014 for structural design.
- Maintaining and extending the Cali accelerograph network (RAC) and its interoperability with the SGC national network.
- Insuring public infrastructure against seismic risk, and retrofitting low-income housing through subsidies and safe self-build programmes.
- Financing model for the priority measures: local government 30-50%, national disaster fund (FNGRD/UNGRD) 30-50%, international partners including JICA, the GEM Foundation and the IDB about 20%.

The 2026 earthquake was not this scenario

The 10 August event was larger in magnitude (M7.4) but 107 km deep and 166 km from Cali, giving the city MMI VI rather than the near-field shaking of the modelled M6.5. Cali recorded 27 deaths and 25-30 collapsed structures — two orders of magnitude below the scenario. What it did test is exactly the weakness the local plan had flagged: about 30% of the University Hospital collapsed and seven health institutions closed. The city's own worst case remains ahead of it, and the case for retrofitting indispensable buildings is now evidential rather than theoretical.

Sources: GEM Foundation — TREQ project (urban earthquake risk, Quito / Cali / Santiago de los Caballeros) · GEM-TREQ — Evaluación de riesgo sísmico para Santiago de Cali (technical report D2.6.2) · Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali — disaster risk management

Historical Earthquakes in Colombia

Year	Event	Mag.	Impact
1906	Ecuador-Colombia earthquake (Pacific coast)	**M8.8**	One of the largest earthquakes ever recorded; destructive tsunami on the Pacific coast
1925	Cali earthquake (Valle del Cauca)	**M7.0**	The reference historical event for Cali; the city was also shaken in 1995 and 2004, the latter damaging clinics and residential buildings
1979	Tumaco earthquake (Nariño)	**M8.1**	Subduction-interface event with tsunami; several hundred deaths
1983	Popayán earthquake (Cauca)	**M5.5**	About 250-300 deaths; historic city centre heavily damaged - a small but shallow, urban event
1994	Páez (Cauca) earthquake	**M6.8**	About 1,100 deaths, most caused by earthquake-triggered landslides and debris flows
1995	Chocó earthquake	**M6.6**	Intermediate-depth event in the same department as the 2026 earthquake
1999	Armenia (Quindío) earthquake	**M6.1-6.2**	About 1,185 deaths; Colombia's costliest earthquake disaster; drove the modern DRM reforms

Pattern
Colombia's deadliest earthquakes have not been its largest. Popayán 1983 (M5.5), Páez 1994 (M6.8) and Armenia 1999 (M6.1-6.2) were all shallow and close to towns; the largest events, offshore in 1906 and 1979, killed fewer people. Depth and proximity, not magnitude alone, drive the toll.

Sources: USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · Servicio Geológico Colombiano (SGC) · GEM - Seismic regulations for Colombia (NSR-10)

Observations & Points to Watch

[Official] A deep source with shallow-disaster consequences. At 107 km depth the earthquake produced no surface rupture and no tsunami, yet it damaged buildings in at least six departments. Damage is dispersed rather than concentrated, which complicates needs assessment, logistics and the targeting of search and rescue.

[Official] Critical facilities failed. The collapse of about 30% of Cali's University Hospital, the closure of seven health institutions, damage to 52 schools and the partial collapse of an international airport terminal all reduce response capacity exactly where it is needed. Seismic performance of hospitals, schools and transport terminals is the clearest lesson emerging so far.

[Official] Figures will rise and will not be internally consistent for some time. Departmental death tolls announced by governors and mayors do not yet sum to the national total, and building-damage counts reflect first-look reporting, not damage assessment. Rapid increases in the coming days should be read as assessment progressing, not necessarily as the situation worsening.

[Media] The affected area is the Coffee Region rebuilt after 1999. Comparing how post-1999 construction performed against older stock, under a very different type of shaking, will be valuable for the region and for other countries with intermediate-depth seismic sources.

[Official] The assessments existed before the event. Cali's GEM-TREQ risk model and its local plan had already named hospitals and other indispensable buildings as the priority to retrofit, and the 2026 earthquake — a far weaker test than the city's own modelled scenario — still took out roughly 30% of its main public hospital. The gap here is not knowledge but implementation and financing.

[Official] Aftershock risk to damaged buildings. The intraslab aftershock sequence is expected to be modest, but damaged structures have lost capacity; rapid structural inspection (habitability assessment) before re-occupancy is the immediate priority alongside search and rescue.

[TBC] Points to watch: the reconciled national casualty figures; shelter and displacement numbers, which have not yet been published; water and power restoration in Chocó; the results of satellite-based damage mapping; and whether the Government requests international assistance beyond the offers already made.

Sources: UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management · USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page) · ReliefWeb - Colombia

Useful Links & Sources (1/3)

Source policy: Source hierarchy: official > media > TBC. Government and scientific-agency figures are used as primary; media reports are used only where official figures are not yet published and are labelled as such. Items still being verified are marked TBC. Preliminary figures are never replaced by larger unverified numbers.

Source	Tier	URL
USGS - M 7.4 San José del Palmar, Colombia (event page)	Official	https://earthquake.usgs.gov/earthquakes/eventpage/us6000tjl2/executive
Servicio Geológico Colombiano (SGC)	Official	https://www.sgc.gov.co/
SGC — event bulletin SGC2026pqqmro (this earthquake)	Official	https://www.sgc.gov.co/detallesismo/SGC2026pqqmro/
SGC — macroseismic intensity map (ShakeMap) for this earthquake	Official	https://www.sgc.gov.co/detallesismo/SGC2026pqqmro/mmi
UNGRD - National Unit for Disaster Risk Management	Official	https://portal.gestiondelriesgo.gov.co/
GDACS - Orange earthquake alert, Colombia, 10 Aug 2026	Official	https://gdacs.org/report.aspx?eventid=1557236&eventtype=EQ
International Charter 'Space and Major Disasters' - activations	Official	https://disasterscharter.org/activations
Copernicus EMS — EMSR916 'Earthquake in Colombia' (activation)	Official	https://mapping.emergency.copernicus.eu/activations/EMSR916/
ReliefWeb - Colombia	Official	https://reliefweb.int/country/col
PAHO/WHO - Colombia	Official	https://www.paho.org/en/colombia
PreventionWeb - Colombia PNGRD 2015-2030	Official	https://www.preventionweb.net/publication/colombia-plan-nacional-de-gestion-del-riesgo-de-desastres-pngrd-2015-2030
GEM - Seismic regulations for Colombia (NSR-10)	Official	https://www.globalquakemodel.org/seismic-regulations/colombia
UN-SPIDER - UNGRD of Colombia	Official	https://un-spider.org/national-unit-disaster-risk-management-ungrd-colombia
OECD - Risk governance scan of Colombia	Official	https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/risk-governance-scan-of-colombia_eeb81954-en.html
CNN - Live updates: at least 111 dead	Media	https://www.cnn.com/2026/08/10/world/live-news/colombia-earthquake-san-jose-del-palmar

Useful Links & Sources (2/3)

Source	Tier	URL
France 24 - Colombia declares national emergency as quake toll hits 111	Media	https://www.france24.com/en/americas/20260810-powerful-quake-rocks-colombia-causing-major-damage
Al Jazeera - M7.4 earthquake hits Colombia	Media	https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/10/7-4-magnitude-earthquake-hits-colombia-killing-at-least-20
CBS News - Strong earthquake strikes western Colombia	Media	https://www.cbsnews.com/news/colombia-earthquake-western-region-evacuations/
NBC News - Deaths, injuries and collapsed buildings	Media	https://www.nbcnews.com/world/latin-america/strong-earthquake-colombia-ecuador-people-evacuating-homes-buildings-rcna591709
Colombia One - First official assessment: widespread structural damage	Media	https://colombiaone.com/2026/08/10/earthquake-colombia-official-details/
Colombia One - Government declares national disaster	Media	https://colombiaone.com/2026/08/10/colombia-national-disaster/
Infobae - SGC explains why the shaking lasted so long	Media	https://www.infobae.com/colombia/2026/08/10/por-que-el-temblor-en-colombia-de-este-lunes-10-de-agosto-duro-una-eternidad-el-servicio-geologico-explico-que-paso/
NHK - President reports 111 dead, 87 injured (Japanese)	Media	https://www3.nhk.or.jp/news/
Nikkei - M7.4 earthquake in western Colombia (Japanese)	Media	https://www.nikkei.com/article/DGXZQOGN108V30Q6A810C2000000/
Jiji Press - M7.4 earthquake in Colombia (Japanese)	Media	https://www.jiji.com/jc/article?k=2026081000878&g=int
Save the Children - Children at risk after the earthquake	Media	https://www.savethechildren.org/us/about-us/media-and-news/2026-press-releases/children-at-risk-after-earthquake-strikes-colombia
Direct Relief - Mobilising medical aid	Media	https://www.directrelief.org/2026/08/colombia-earthquake-7-4-magnitude-direct-relief-response/
Americares - Colombia earthquake, August 2026	Media	https://www.americares.org/crisis-alerts/colombia-earthquake-august-2026/
GLIDEnumber — EQ-2026-000146-COL (event identifier)	Official	https://glidenumber.net/
ADRC - Asian Disaster Reduction Center	Official	https://www.adrc.asia/

Useful Links & Sources (3/3)

Source	Tier	URL
European Commission — EU support for Colombia, Copernicus activated	Media	https://www.democrata.es/en/international/von-der-leyen-expresses-the-eu-s-support-for-colombia-and-activates-copernicus-after-the-earthquake/
GEM Foundation — TREQ project (urban earthquake risk, Quito / Cali / Santiago de los Caballeros)	Official	https://www.globalquakemodel.org/proj/treq
GEM-TREQ — Evaluación de riesgo sísmico para Santiago de Cali (technical report D2.6.2)	Official	https://cloud-storage.globalquakemodel.org/public/wix-new-website/pdf-collections-wix/publications/TREQ%20deliverables/reports/TREQ_D262_Riesgo_Sismico_Cali_v1.00.pdf
Understanding seismic risk in Santiago de Cali for its application in risk management (peer-reviewed, 2025)	Official	https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S2212420925003097
SATIC — Cali's intelligent and community early warning system	Official	https://satic.cali.gov.co/satic
Alcaldía de Santiago de Cali — disaster risk management	Official	https://www.cali.gov.co/gestiondelriesgo/
UNGRD — Plan Nacional de Gestión del Riesgo de Desastres (PNGRD)	Official	https://portal.gestiondelriesgo.gov.co/Paginas/Plan-Nacional-de-Gestion-del-Riesgo.aspx
Decreto 1478 de 2022 — update of the PNGRD	Official	https://www.funcionpublica.gov.co/eva/gestornormativo/norma.php?i=191411

Asian Disaster Reduction Center (ADRC)

Bilingual (EN/JA) report for domestic and international dissemination. Public-agency sources take priority; gaps are filled with clearly-labelled media reports.

Figures as of 10 Aug 2026, 17:00 COT (11 Aug 07:00 JST), approx. 9.5 hours after the earthquake. All figures are preliminary.

https://www.adrc.asia/